

centre of the field and I went and hit a few balls," recalls Hardik.

He was able to step onto the pitch in one of the highest-profile matches played in India because of the reputation his *chacha*, Gurmail Singh, enjoyed. Gurmail was not only an officer with the Punjab Police but also a member of the last Indian team to win Olympic hockey gold — at the 1980 Moscow Games.

While Hardik would later win two Olympic medals himself — bronze at both the Tokyo and Paris Games — he remembers being in awe of his uncle.

"I'd grown up hearing stories about his Olympic gold, and I always wondered what it would be like to have one of my own. But the funny thing is I never got to see his medal because he never had it up for display, and I was too shy to ask him," he says.

No shortage of inspiration

Gurmail's Olympic medal was one of five won by players from Khusropur, near Jalandhar in Punjab. "This is a village known for hockey. The saying used to be that when a child was born in Khusropur, they would place a hockey stick next to him," says Gurmail.

Even within Khusropur, the family's association with the sport stands out. Gurmail is the youngest brother of Hardik's grandfather Preetam, who coached the Indian Navy team. Gurmail's wife, Rajbir Kaur, was part of the Indian women's team that won gold at the 1982 Asian Games. Hardik's father, too, had been part of the national camp.

Their connection with the sport goes back even further. "My grandfather, Jagat Singh Rai, was originally from Pakistan. He wasn't a hockey player but a wrestler. He was in the Army, and his son — my father, Gurdayal Rai — joined the 2 Sikh Light Infantry. He learnt hockey in the Army and that's where our family's connection to the sport began," says Gurmail.

All six of Gurmail's brothers played hockey, including Hardik's grandfather. "When I was in 7th class my father became seriously ill. Before he passed away, he asked my eldest



A family of excellence: Hardik's family comes from a village known for its hockey heritage. While his grand uncle Gurmail Singh was a member of the last Indian team to win Olympic hockey gold at the 1980 Moscow Games, Gurmail's wife Rajbir Kaur, was part of the Indian women's team that won gold at the 1982 Asian Games. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

brother [Hardik's grandfather] to help me become a good player. After he passed away, I was the one who was given the most support," he recalls.

It was perhaps natural, then, that Gurmail would return the favour with Hardik. "When I was a child, my *chacha* would take me to Jalandhar to watch matches at the Surjit Singh Hockey Tournament. I'd watch those matches and think I'd be playing like them some day. He also told me stories about domestic and international players who had played in India. He once told me about Sohail Abbas, the Pakistani drag-flicker, who hit a shot so hard it tore the net," recalls Hardik.

Different eras

Hardik relished these conversations. "Sometimes I'd wonder what it would be like if I played in previous eras like my *chacha's*. I wondered if I would be as good. But things were so different that it's hard to say. Back then you had to be on the field for 70 minutes with no rolling substitutions, so the pace was much slower. You could also take drag-flicks from inside the circle, so those were really hard to stop," he says.

Gurmail agrees the game has

changed, and not just at the elite level. "The facilities available now are far better than anything we had. We mostly played on grass and sometimes even that wasn't there. But I can say with confidence that the level of competition was much higher simply because hockey was a mass sport then. Now it is mostly played in academies. It isn't played as much at school or college levels," he says.

Despite minor disagreements about the sport's evolution, the bond between Hardik and Gurmail has always been defined by support and respect. When Hardik broke into the senior Indian team, Gurmail offered him advice.

"I told him what I had learnt. I advised him not to get into controversy. Respect everyone and work hard. Come first and leave last," says Gurmail.

Supportive cousin

While Hardik respects and admires his grand uncle, the difference in age and seniority creates a natural distance, a gap that doesn't exist with Gurmail's son, Shubh.

"It's strange because for a long time I didn't think I was going to be the best player in the family. It was Shubh who I felt was really good. Everyone else thought so, too. After